

models. The inclusion of HDR (High Dynamic Range) into *HL2*'s Source engine means that the lighting is spectacular.

Characters

Alyx and Dog (her pet robot) are back with you, and Alyx is a big help throughout *HL2:EP1*. Alyx, as usual, is integral to the storyline, and you just cannot get past a lot of doors without her and her magic *Combine-force-field-door-shorter-outer*. She's not invincible though, so don't leave her standing around fighting Antlions while you cower in a corner!

Towards the end you meet up with Barney again, but only for a short while. There are some characters that remind you of *Half Life 2*, and, in fact, I swear there's one scene in *HL2:EP1* that's identical to a scene in the beginning of *HL2*—see screenshot 15 and see if it rings any bells! All the characters are more believable though, but only because they swear a little every now and then—a lot better than the squeaky-clean *HL2* dialog!

Maps And Graphics

If you've played *HL2*, you'll remember Ravenholm and Highway 17, and also City 17—*HL2:EP1* takes place only in City 17. The maps are pretty standard, the secrets and puzzles easy to find and solve, and path finding is a snap. The new maps are not nearly as vast as *HL2*, which is a good or bad thing—depending solely on what you prefer. I just preferred getting lost in the *HL2* maps, which made the whole experience more realistic—especially since I'm geographically challenged in real life anyway!

The graphics, however, are superb, and are a lot better than in *Half Life 2*—just the addition of HDR makes a world of a difference.

Weapons

All the same, and you don't find them all in *Episode 1*. As I mentioned earlier, you start with the Gravity Gun (GG), then find the pistol and submachine guns after you kill a few Combine soldiers. When you finally meet Barney, he hands you the infamous crowbar, making some really corny, yet hilarious remarks about it. As it turns out, the only weapons you *need* are the GG, the shotgun and the missile launcher—you can easily finish a game using only these.

Story

To tell you the story, we'll use screenshots, but you should know that it's nothing as vast and engrossing as *HL2*, and is over before you know it. It took me 3 hours to finish *Episode 1*, and it shouldn't take even first time *Half Lifers* more than 6 hours to finish it. But, then again, how much more can you expect from a \$20 (Rs 900) episode?

I was very disappointed by the usage of time though, and I felt a lot more should have happened in those 3 hours that I was playing. Overall, just the Ravenholm level in *HL2*—which sent shivers down my spine the first time I played it—was more entertaining than this entire episode. Overall, I'll give *Episode 1* a rating of 7/10, because it was way too short and was pale in comparison to *Half Life 2*.

Of course you should also know that I will be one of the first to download and buy *Episode 2* when it's released!

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Rating: 7/10

Developer: Valve

<http://ep1.half-life.com>



5 ...then I get a car thrown back at me for my trouble



6 She loves the stupid Dog more than me



11 She's scared! I use my gun barrel to calm her down



12 Darkness and bugs should make her happier



17 Strider, strider burning bright. A fight at last!



18 There goes City 17; time for *Episode 2*, and lunch...

